

Tea Tea

A Recipe Book By:
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This book is dedicated to my Mama, who accidentally lets the Chai boil over the pot at least twice a week; the Chaiwallas in India, selling their delicacy whether it's a scorching 104 degrees or a freezing 32 degrees outside; to my Papa, whose devotion was measured in spoonfuls of Mishri; to Alan, the Starbucks Employee at the Plaza who has perfected the ratio between Vanilla Cold Foam and Chai Concentrate; and to my friends, who, I promise, are not actually racist.

The word “chai” literally translates to “tea” in Hindi, but really refers to a strong, black Assam powder, boiled with milk and spices such as cardamom, cloves, cinnamon, and ginger. Globally, it is consumed by hundreds of millions of people in some form every day. In India alone, over a billion cups are drunk daily. At an average price of 10 to 30 rupees, less than a dollar a cup, it becomes a multi-generational, habitual routine, with people drinking two to three servings per day. In Indian culture, chai is more than a recipe; it is a routine, an income, and a ritual rather than a specialty order at Starbucks. Or an order people indulge in when they crave something milky and sweet but don’t want a Coffee. Every day in the United States, tens of millions of cups are sold and consumed at four to seven dollars a cup. East or West, chai has made a lasting connection with people worldwide; in my case, this comforting drink has played a hand in shaping who I am today.

Mama's Chai

Bring 3 cups of water to a boil.

Grate in about a tablespoon of ginger.

Add 4 teaspoons of chai pathi.

Add 8 teaspoons of sugar.

Add 4 crushed pods of cardamom.

Mix and bring to a boil.

Add half a cup of milk,
or add until you reach your desired color.

Mix and bring to a boil,
repeating this process at least 4 times.

Strain into your chosen mug.



Mama's Chai:

My mom used to tell me chai heals all. One sip of the 'liquid gold' would cure a cough, cold, fever, cramps — everything. Though not scientifically proven, her words had convinced me enough to return to the ritual every day. At 4:15 PM, without fail, we would gather in our kitchen and lay out tea cups and coasters, decorating the dining table with our staple snacks and biscuit tins. It was an unspoken tradition, the one time my family and I would disregard whatever it was that we were doing, and come together to enjoy our sacred potion. As the chai bubbled in my mom's copper pot, the familiar fragrance grew and grew, until the air was resplendent with the scent of ginger and cardamom, and the tranquility that came with it.

Bad test grades, arguments between friends, stressful conversations, even sometimes the deafening silence that follows altercations with my parents would come and go, but still our ritual at 4:15 remained untouched. Wherever we were in the house, as the warming aroma of spices filled the hallways, we would drift to the kitchen and settle into our unspoken 'assigned' seats, a routine so familiar it felt instinctive. And for those couple of moments, the world stopped. The stress we carried, about working on projects or studying for tests, anything and everything, faded away until all that remained was our chai and each other.

Looking back, perhaps it wasn't the chai that healed all; it was the ritual instead. The comfort and certainty of knowing that no matter how chaotic our lives had become, we could always return to the same table, at the same time, eating the same snacks, and drinking the same chai together. It wasn't that chai could cure cough, cold, fever, cramps — everything, it was that chai gave us something steady to hold onto. A quiet constant, even as everything changed and moved around us.

As I grew older, I realized our 4:15 chai ritual was not unique to my family.

Around the world, people cling to small routines that bring comfort to their ever-changing lives. Whether it is an evening walk, a brief conversation with next-door neighbors, or a cup of chai shared between strangers at a street food stall, these rituals often carry a meaning far deeper than the act itself.

They become markers of familiarity, grounding people during some of the most chaotic moments of their lives.

Masala Chai

Bring 1 cup of water and 1 cup of milk to a boil.

Add a 1-inch piece of crushed ginger,

Add 1-2 cinnamon sticks,

Add 3-4 pods of cardamom, crushed into a coarse powder,

Add two cloves,

Add one black peppercorn, crushed into a coarse powder,

**Let the water and spices come to a boil,
allowing the spices to infuse.**

After the mixture has come to a boil,

Add in 1.5-2 tablespoons of chai.

**Turn the heat down,
and let this mixture simmer for 2-3 minutes.**

Add 1.5-2 tablespoons of sugar.

**Let this mixture come to its final boil,
for about 3-4 minutes.**

**Turn off the heat, and strain the hot chai into clay cups
for the most authenticity.**

This recipe is sufficient for about 2 cups of chai.

Masala Chai

At 7:30 sharp, the air swells with cardamom.
 The chaiwallas call their familiar phrase
 “10 rupee, 10 rupee,”
 Stacks of Parle-G tucked beneath wooden carts,
 softening in the heat.

They are reminded of those
 who have mastered the art of pouring,
 measuring sugar and ginger by instinct,
 their hands moving like memory,
 their eyes closed.

And when they take the first sip,
 They are comforted,
 The drinkers feel the hot liquid,
 coursing through their throat,
 With each swallow bringing peace and ease.
 And for a moment,
 The city slows.

The honking fades into the background,
 The dust settles under tired feet,
 Strangers standing shoulder to shoulder,
 Different lives, different stories,
 Sharing a cup of unity.

No one asks where they are going,
 No one asks where they've been,
 They simply drink,
 The same way their mothers did,
 The same way their fathers did,

The world moves forward,
 The trains leave, the markets open,
 Children grow, homes change,
 Lives are created and lost,
 But chai remains

Boiling,
 Spilling,
 Sweetening the air,
 Returning each person
 To something they know.
 The comfort they crave

A constant in a country of motion.
 The ritual held between two hands,
 The solidarity that comes with it
 A reminder that even in change,
 Some things stay warm.

Unlike certain chai rituals that brought comfort through routine, some practices carried a deeper promise. In many Hindu and Jain households, prasad is offered to the different representations of God kept within the home. Usually in the form of fruit or different types of sweets, it is first presented as an offering before being returned as a blessing to those who eat it.

Growing up, I thought I understood what that blessing meant. What was given to God came back transformed. I believed our offerings would return to us as protection.

And nowhere did that belief feel more real than during Papa's weekly morning prayers.

Mishri Chai

Bring 3 cups of water to a boil.

Grate in about a tablespoon of ginger,

Along with 3 whole cloves.

Add 4 teaspoons of chai pathi.

Add 1 handful of Mishri.

Add 4 crushed pods of cardamom.

Mix and bring to a boil.

Add half a cup of milk, or add until you reach your
desired color.

Mix and bring to a boil, repeating this process at least 4
times.

Strain into your chosen mug.



Mishri Chai

Every Friday morning, before going to work, Papa made his mandatory stop in our makeshift temple that shared a room with his office. He would stand in front of a carved wooden sculpture of Mahavir Bhagwan, reaching into a plastic container stored in the bottom cabinet, next to boxes of ghee and trays of rakhis. Inside was Mishri—pieces of crystallized sugar that are usually used as an offering in Jainism—which he carefully scooped onto a steel plate beside a small diya. Then, as he lights the Diya, he begins to sing a familiar bhajan. The Sanskrit verses seemed to flow effortlessly from him, engulfing the room in a mellow rhythm. I used to sit nearby, occupying his office chair as I watched the glow of the diya light up his face. While I stumbled through the verses, trying to recall the Hindi lyrics of *Om Jai Mahavir Prabhu*, he seamlessly recited every word as though reading directly from the *Jinvani*. Listening closely, it felt as though those prayers belonged to him; in a way, they never worked for anyone else in the family.

And when it came time to make our afternoon chai, we would stir the Mishri he had offered to God into our chai, replacing the sugar. By the time the sugar dissolved, the ritual was complete, and a small piece of God's blessing had come back to protect us in every sip of our chai. And I thought that if God was watching anyone, surely it would be the man who had never missed a Friday prayer and who knew every verse to dozens of Bhajans by heart. I believed devotion like that was enough to guarantee protection.

I was walking into my fourth-period Biology class when I found out. A stream of texts flooded my family group chat. "Why are u guys in the ER?" my sister sent. She always tracked us from her college dorm, checking in from afar to make sure everything was in place back at home. When I opened the FindMy app to see my parents' icons covering the gray box labeled El Camino Hospital, a wave of confusion stopped me in my tracks.

I blew up my mom's phone with messages, "Are u ok?", "Why are u guys in the hospital?", "Did something happen to Papa?" When I got home that afternoon, my parents still hadn't returned from their unexplained hospital trip. I sat down at my desk, hoping to get some homework done, but my brain wouldn't move past the feeling that something was really wrong. My leg started tapping on the ground at the same quick rhythm as my heart.

When I finally called my mom, the shaky feeling I had in my gut kept growing bigger and bigger with every ring. Once she picked up, she gave me limited information. "Papa tik hai par rath me rehna hoyega." Papa is fine, she explained, but he will have to stay overnight. My mom came home later that night with tired eyes and a hastily packed purse weighing heavily on her arm. In her hand was a large folder, which she placed on the edge of the kitchen island as she went to wash off the stench of the hospital. On the top of the front page of the packet in bold letters was one word: STROKE.

The word hit me like a slap in the face. I had only ever associated the word with death, drawing from movies I had watched or distant stories I had heard from next-door neighbors and close friends. At the time, I was unfamiliar with how it would end up changing my family. How my dad would never be the same again. For the next couple of days, my mom lived at the hospital, and I bounced between family friends' houses, wondering when my life would return to normal. The first time I visited my dad in the hospital, I couldn't hold back my tears. I spent hours just observing him, seeing how he'd lost his strength, and how his beard had grown from days of not having his razor. I overheard the doctors talking with my mom, discussing his condition. "He lost a lot of his memory and strength, but he is pushing through," one said. The beeping of the machines was steady, calm, and even; a consistent soundtrack accompanying my racing mind.

The hospital room was a dull, moldy shade of green, with the paint chipping near the windowsill that overlooked the parking lot. It smelled like hand sanitizer, but there was a strange sort of tranquility that came with it. The building was almost too quiet and too calm. Through the silence, I heard my mom's shaky breathing each time she exhaled. My leg was tapping on the ground at the same quick rhythm as my heart. I watched my dad's chest go up and down, wondering how we had wound up in this position.

I would try to talk to Papa, to remind him that he had reasons to fight. Our conversations were simple. I'd tell him about my day, things like what I had eaten for lunch or how my classes were going. He would nod occasionally, but never talk. I felt tears trickling down my face every time we would 'talk', not because of sadness, but because I wasn't used to seeing my dad in such a fragile state. I was confused as to how something so depleting could happen to someone I had always associated with strength.

The faint, inconsistent scent of hand sanitizer and antiseptics accompanied the doctors and nurses who were constantly filing in and out of the room. Until, finally, one addressed my mom using unfamiliar words, referring to the stroke as something I had never heard before. But one thing he said stuck in my mind: "He will get through this."

And I tried my hardest to believe him, but as I looked at Papa lying in that hospital bed, I couldn't disregard how wrong I had been all those years. I had treated Papa's Friday morning prayers like proof he was protected. If anyone in my life was safe against something like this, it was supposed to be him.

For weeks, I couldn't get it out of my head. Every time I stepped foot into that hospital room, I found myself reminded of our makeshift temple and how I had convinced myself that those rituals signified a promise rather than just faith. An assurance that the people closest to God would somehow be spared from the hardships of life. But still, the state of Papa had proved my previous idea wrong. His stroke was not a result of devotion, because his devotion is not what was capable of protecting him in the first place.

Every battle his body put him through, he fought with everything and won. Every milestone he passed on his path to recovery belonged to him. But still, I had countless questions, wondering things like, " Why did God let him suffer? Force him to relearn how to hold a pencil and walk. Force my mom to spend hours sitting by his hospital bed, contacting relatives with every update the doctors had for us. Make her look at my dad and question if she was going to be able to spend the rest of her life by his side. Why did God make my sister have to hide her tears every time she called us? Why did he choose a time when she and I were separated? When both of us felt like we were going through something so big, alone. And those questions never really disappeared. What did change was the answer I was looking for.

When Papa came home, he brought a tense aura with him. Posters on our fridge, covered with the acronym GFAST—G for gaze fixed in one direction, F for facial droop, A for weakness in the arms or legs, S for slurred or confused speech, and T for ‘time lost is brain lost’. The laminated magnetized label stood as a warning for the rest of our lives, a reason to stay on edge.

For a long time, every time I saw that poster, I thought of it as evidence that our faith had failed us. But eventually, I had come to terms with what those Friday prayers were meant to do all along. They were never supposed to be protection from suffering, but preparation for when the unavoidable strikes. The stroke Papa faced didn’t show me that he wasn’t close to God; it showed me what devotion looked like outside of a temple. Through every milestone Papa conquered in Physical Therapy, through the quiet persistence that carried him through his recovery process. It was the same consistency and dedication that he brought to his Friday morning prayers.

Now, whenever I help make our Friday afternoon chai, as I pour in the Mishri that was once sitting beside the Diya in our temple, I see something different. What I had once correlated with protection, I see as a sign of resilience. I see family. I see my dad, a man whose greatest act of faith wasn’t the prayers he recited every Friday morning, but the strength he found to fight when God stopped answering them

For most of my life, I believed the meaning of chai was confined to the walls of my home. To my family, chai represented comfort, routine, and the traditions we carried with us long after leaving India behind. I never imagined that something so ordinary to us could be viewed so differently outside those walls.

It was only recently that my perspective began to shift. I realized that chai carried different meanings depending on who was holding the cup.

In Hindi, chai literally translates to tea, making the phrase “chai tea latte” essentially mean “tea tea latte.” For years, I never thought twice about that contradiction—until one particular morning.

Iced Chai Tea Latte

Add ½ a cup of chai concentrate into a large mixer,

Add ⅓ - ½ a cup of your choice of milk into the mixer,

Shut the lid and mix till both are incorporated.

Add to a fresh serving cup,

In a small mixing bowl,

Add in ½ a cup of heavy cream,

And 3 pumps of vanilla syrup,

Using a handheld frother,

Mix the cream until it has reached your desired consistency,

Add this into the same cup as the drink.

Serve and Enjoy!



Iced Chai Tea Latte

We were sitting at a table during third period when I first heard it. The sound of aggressive chatter, music playing over foggy speakers, with the sound of Hindi coming out of the phone speaker, “Ek lehlo, Ek lehlo, Char Rupee, Char Rupee.” The familiar cadence drew my attention to my friend’s screen, lit up by a TikTok of a street vendor selling her masala chai in the crowded markets of New Delhi. I narrowed my gaze as he opened the comments section filled with words blurring together: “Ewww, I would never eat that.” “1% food, 99% bacteria.” I will never eat Indian food!”

I turned to my friend, only to see a smile widening into a grimacing laugh on his face. The kind of laugh that spreads quickly—pulling others in, making it feel normal, expected. The people around him tuned in to the video as it replayed over and over. Their reactions overlapped with the comments on the screen, blurring the line between what was online and what was right in front of me.

And then, almost automatically, I laughed too.

It crept out of me quietly, just enough to be heard, just enough to blend into the chuckles of my friends. I nodded slightly as they sorted through more comments, as though I agreed and understood. As though I wasn’t a part of what they were laughing at. But I was.

A laugh that distanced me from the video, from the woman on the screen, from the foreign language that only seconds before had felt familiar. But at that moment, I wasn’t defending my culture. I was separating myself from it. Because it felt easier than explaining. Easier than risking the pause that might follow if I didn’t laugh or speak up. Easier than trying to show my friends that that wasn’t what India was really like. Easier than being seen as different.

And for a second, it worked. I blended in. The moment passed. The video ended.

But my discomfort didn’t.

As the day continued, I couldn’t shake the feeling of confusion and regret. Those comments replayed in my head, they stuck with me during the rest of the school day, Lacrosse practice, and even on the way home. Not because I had believed them, but because I had laughed along. A few days later, my friends and I had found ourselves at our usual lunch spot, the Starbucks in the Plaza. We stood in line, gossiping about something that had happened earlier that day and scrolling through TikTok. And when it was finally my time to order, I recited my order perfectly, as if it were muscle memory.

“Hi! Can I please have a Grande Iced chai Tea Latte with Vanilla Cold Foam and light ice?”

The irony had hit me almost immediately. Days earlier, I had laughed at my friends mocking a lady on TikTok, selling chai in a crowded market. But here I was, about to spend \$7.75 on a polished version of the same drink. And nobody looked at me with a disgusted face, wrinkled their nose, or called it unsanitary.

Then it clicked, it wasn't the drink that was different, it was the setting.

Chai was seen as sophisticated when it was placed in a paper cup with a green logo on it. But when it came to a street vendor speaking Hindi, chai was disgusting, filled with bacteria, and a target for constant ridiculing. Holding that cold Starbucks cup, I realized I had turned my culture into a punchline. Laughing along with my friends' jokes, sometimes even adding my own, I realized I had spent so much time trying to fit in that I had disregarded a crucial part of my identity.

No one at that third-period table had forced me to laugh. No one at that table had told me to reject where I had come from, and that is what stung me more. But I can't say that I have learned from this experience and that I won't let anything come in the way of me standing up for my culture, because that is simply not true. Sometimes it is easier to fall into societal stereotypes than to constantly have to prove yourself and your culture as 'clean' or 'bacteria-free'.

Sometimes it is easier to fall into stereotypes than to constantly feel the need to defend your culture as "clean" or "acceptable". Sometimes it feels easier to order an Iced Chai Tea Latte than explain why the version sold in New Delhi deserves the same appreciation. For years, I thought acceptance meant distancing myself from parts of my identity. Now I realize how much of myself I have traded away in the process.

As my life continues, I have come to see chai as more than just a drink. It brings my family a familiar comfort through our 4:15 rituals. It represents community in the crowded, bustling streets of India. It reflects the devotion and faith woven into Papa's Friday morning prayers. But mostly, it symbolizes my own identity.

Whether shared around a kitchen table, offered as prasad, or served in a Starbucks cup, chai has taught me that even the simplest traditions can carry the deepest meaning.

I hope this recipe book has taught you something, too, and perhaps encouraged you to look differently at the small rituals woven into your everyday life.

Best,

Prisha Jain